Binaguri was a military station in the middle of nowhere; it didn't even have a railway station of its own. Although classified as a peace station, there were no civil amenities in the vicinity, no proper schools or colleges nor cinemas or shopping centres. Although the military station itself was well laid out with basic amenities, including a military hospital, the sense of isolation was complete, made even more so by the hot and humid climate and dense undergrowth. For the slightest requirement, one had to drive to Siliguri about four hours away, on potholed village roads. Being a peace station, 100 per cent married accommodation had been catered for in the planning stage, but due to the lack of many facilities, not all families joined, especially those officers with children in senior classes. As a result, a great portion of the accommodation was vacant and houses not occupied were going to seed. This was a mismatch I was to see quite often, between expectations and ground reality, leading to wasteful expenditure.

At Binaguri, we were part of 66 Mountain Brigade under 20 Mountain Division, the reserve division of the Corps, with the operational role in Sikkim. Whenever required, we would move in convoys from Binaguri to our first-stage acclimatization area ahead of Gangtok on the road leading to Nathu La. As the reserves, we had several counter-attack (CA) tasks spread over North and East Sikkim. Being the reserve is a difficult job as compared to being deployed in a defensive role, but on the other hand, you get to see much more of the operational area. For each of the CA tasks, the officers would first carry out a reconnaissance and then make a plan catering for various contingencies. This would be followed by a skeleton exercise involving just the commanders and some specialist personnel. We would then have two full rehearsals for each task, once by day and once by night. Walking up and down those steep

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